

Sierra Club WTC 2009 – Group 2 / Modjeska Snow Travel Day, South Fork trailhead near San Geronio February 21st, 2009

Saturday was the next outing for the Sierra Club WTC (Wilderness Travel Course) that I'm helping teach this year. Snow travel day is the third and final outing before the infamous snow camp. The purpose is to both get the students comfortable on snowshoes and to allow the chance to test out boots and other gear before we're 4 miles up a closed road in the Sierra's hip deep in snow.

It also allows us to demonstrate various snow skills, practice navigation with somewhat obscured terrain, and of course have snowball fights.

In 2007 when I was a student we had did snow travel day on Mt Waterman up in the Angeles Forest area and to my joy and delight the weather turned from boring sunshine to near whiteout conditions as several inches of snow dumped on us.



Much to my disappointment this year the forecast didn't show any chance of snowfall. Instead we were looking at 50 degree weather and sunshine. Bleh. On the positive side a storm several weeks ago caused a significant amount of snowfall which meant we would at least have enough snow on the ground.

This year instead of Waterman we went to the San Geronio South Fork trailhead, the same area I led the rather frigid backpack to last October.



I was traveling to Boise again that week for work and so after getting back into town late Friday evening Kim and I rolled out of bed painfully early Saturday morning and drove to the carpool point to meet the rest of the class.

Our car made an impromptu stop for breakfast along the way...



We arrived at the trailhead and there was indeed an encouraging amount of snow.



After getting the snowshoes handed out and making sure we were all accounted for we were off.



We were a restrained group...



Very focused on our task...



And then during our first nav practice Snowball War 1 broke out...



Soon to be followed by Snowball War 2 (also known as where my camera took a near direct hit)...



And the unforgettable Snowball War 3 (aka everyone throw snowballs at Matt hence the fact there are no pictures).

In between snowball fights we did get some actual work done. Below is the class getting the chance to feel how much work it is to break a trail through fresh snow.



The views were excellent with the clouds staying high enough we could see Sugarloaf...



And even Baldy in the distance...



After hiking in several miles and a brief climb we had lunch on Poopout Hill with a view of San Geronio in the background.



There were others on the hill with us who had viewed our snowball fights and general antics with some amusement.



After lunch we demonstrated various skills for ascending and descending a snowy slope.

On our way back we stopped at Horseshoe Meadow again to have a snowshoe race.



And of course, yet another snowball fight broke out much to the chagrin of the innocent folks who happened to be sitting in the middle of the group.





Alas, in the final snowball war we did have an injury when a student received a cut on the leg after getting clipped by an errant snowshoe crampon during the final charge. We play hard in WTC.

Overall it was a fun day and everyone seemed to enjoy themselves. Now we have the real fun, two weeks and counting until snow camp.